



Courtesy: DAG

**Past perfect:** (Clockwise from left) Hiroshi Yoshida's 'Udeypoor' (Kokka woodblock print on paper, 1931); Richard R. Drabble's 'The Mosque of Aurangzeb' (oil on canvas, 1863); Edwin L. Weeks's 'Native Gharry' (oil on canvas, 1882); Alfred E. Emslie's 'An Indian Street Scene' (watercolour); Charles W. Bartlett's 'The Golden Temple, Amritsar' (Kokka woodblock print on paper, 1919); George Strahan's 'Wular Lake J&K' (watercolour, 1894)

especially the Taj Mahal.

Bartlett's stunning 'Taj Mahal at Sunset (1919, Kokka woodblock on paper, 15x10 inches) is part of the exhibition *Destination India: Foreign Artists in India 1857-1947*, which covers 30-plus artists—from early luminaries such as Edward Lear (1812-88) and William Carpenter (1818-99) to latter-day practitioners like George Strahan (1839-1911), Walter Crane (1845-1915) and Hiroshi Yoshida (1876-1950).

Works from the earlier end of the era (1850s to 1880s) tend to focus on monuments and landscapes. However, from the 1880s onwards, with the advent of both photography and picture postcards, artists began to focus on the Indians they'd come across rather than buildings and vistas. Author and curator Giles Tillotson, whose essay 'Orientalist Painters in India' is a part of the exhibition booklet, says it is a mistake to assume that paintings reduced in prominence during the photography era—historians were simply not looking hard enough or looking in the wrong places.

**DAG Delhi's DESTINATION INDIA: FOREIGN ARTISTS IN INDIA 1857-1947 is on till Aug. 24**

"I think that by the mid-19th century, the camera had replaced paintings as the primary method of recording or documenting India," says Tillotson. "But this meant that artists had to go beyond mere representation, because Samuel Bourne (a British photographer) was already doing it with his camera and doing it better than you ever can. This pushed visiting artists in India to change their methods and bring something else to the table."

That 'something else' was a fresh perspective, often from a British military serviceman, civil servant or their spouses. Strahan was a sapper and then a surveyor before he retired in 1894 and these experiences no doubt informed his post-retirement watercolour paintings. Lena George (active in India between 1915 and 1925) was the wife of Walter Sykes George, a prolific architect who designed the Regal in Connaught Place, Delhi's first-ever cinema hall. She had accompanied her husband across Asia and Africa to various postings, all of which influenced her oil paintings.

"We hope this exhibition takes conversations around foreign artists in India to new directions. One of the things you'll notice about this exhibition is the number of images from Rajasthan," says Tillotson. "Artists visiting India before 1857 seldom visited Rajasthan because the East India Company did not have any meaningful diplomatic or cultural ties with the place." ■

**–Aditya Mani Jha**







Courtesy: CHATTERJEE & LAL

**Two generations:** (Clockwise from above) Cumi Dallas's Untitled historical Buddhist scene (watercolour); Untitled woman wearing jewellery (oil on canvas, 1937); Siodia's Untitled historical Magi and heightened young woman (watercolour, 1929); Cumi's Untitled woman sitting on a lotus (watercolour)

mural decoration in the early 1930s. She was also a recognised portraitist; the Queen of Iran sat for her and her portrait of Madam Cama was installed in the Indian Parliament.

Siodia's idyllic English landscapes contrast with his daughter's slightly edgier style, particularly her dramatic portrayal of the Bombay Docks explosion in 1944. "We had an exhibition of Siodia's in 2019, so this is the second time we're showing him. However, this time we're showing him in the context of his daughter's practice," says gallery director Mortimer Chatterjee. At J.J., Dallas studied under J.M. Ahivasi and became a leading exponent of the Bombay Revivalist School, which synthesised different aspects of indigenous painting like Indian miniature traditions and the Ajanta paintings. The latter is evident in Dallas's 'Untitled (Chaddanta Jataka)', a watercolour on paper circa 1930s, which is on display. "Her works were also influenced by aspects of Western academic paintings like, say, the Renaissance," adds Chatterjee. Case in point is her evocative untitled graphite and watercolour on paper depiction of a group of women revelling in music, dance and drink, which is almost reminiscent of Botticelli's famous 'The Birth of Venus'.

The exhibition is on till August 24 at Chatterjee & Lal, Colaba, Mumbai. ■

**–Prachi Joshi**